

DECISIVE MOMENT October 14, 1066

Battle of Hastings

The Battle of Hastings was fought in southern England between an Anglo-Saxon army under Harold of Wessex and a force of invading Normans led by William of Normandy. The Normans were victorious and their leader became William I of England, known ever since as William the Conqueror.

In 11th-century England, several contenders vied to become king, largely because of the actions of Edward the Confessor (1003–66). In 1051, Edward told William of Normandy that he would be king after Edward's death, but when a Viking invasion looked likely in the early 1060s, Edward made a pledge to the Danish Svein Estrithsson too. Harald Hardraada of Norway had also been promised the throne by an earlier English king. However, English nobles wanted a native ruler, and Edward made yet another oath, this time to Harold of Wessex.

In January 1066, Edward died and Harold took the throne. But he soon faced a challenge—Harald Hardraada invaded northern England. Harold marched north to face his rival in battle and emerged the victor. At the same time, William of Normandy set sail across the English Channel with an invasion force, and landed on the south coast. As soon as he heard the news, Harold marched south, hoping to take the invaders by surprise.

William's scouts were watching for Harold's army, and soon after his arrival the Normans attacked. The

two armies were well matched in numbers, with around 8,000 men each. At first, the English seemed invincible. Their footsoldiers fought in close, efficient formations and their axmen dealt fearsome blows. When a rumor spread that William had been killed, the Norman soldiers started to break up in disarray. But William held up his helmet to show that he was still alive. From then on, the Norman archers and mounted knights dominated the English, who were exhausted after their long march south. Finally Harold was wounded and then, after being set upon by Norman knights, he was killed. William claimed victory.

On December 25, 1066, William was crowned king of England. He quickly strengthened his position by granting lands to his nobles, thereby ensuring the spread of Norman power across the country. For many generations to come, England was ruled by kings from Normandy or other parts of France. The ruling class of England was Norman, the language of government and the court was French, and many senior churchmen were from Norman families.

The Bayeux Tapestry

This unique historical record is a 230-ft- (70-m-) long embroidered panel that tells the story of events leading up to the Battle of Hastings and the battle itself. Although it is thought to have been created in England, it tells the story from a Norman perspective.

“They are a **race inured to war**, and can hardly live without it.”

WILLIAM OF MALMESBURY, FROM “DEEDS OF THE KINGS OF THE ENGLISH,” DESCRIBING THE NORMANS, 12TH CENTURY

